

FREE RESOURCE // THE MASTER OF MUSIC INDUSTRY

Sync Licensing Starter Pack

Sync licensing — placing your music in TV, film, advertising, and video games — is one of the most lucrative revenue streams available to independent artists. A single placement can pay more than a million streams. This guide gets you started.

// WHAT IS SYNC LICENSING?

A sync license grants permission to synchronize your music with visual media. Every time you hear a song in a TV show, commercial, movie, or video game, a sync deal was made. Two licenses are always required:

SYNC LICENSE: Permission to use the composition (melody + lyrics). Granted by the songwriter or publisher.

MASTER LICENSE: Permission to use the specific recording. Granted by whoever owns the master recording.

If you wrote and recorded the song and own both rights, you can license both yourself. This is a significant advantage independent artists have over signed artists whose masters are owned by labels.

// SYNC FEE RANGES BY PLACEMENT TYPE

Placement Type	Typical Fee Range	Notes
Major network TV (per episode)	\$2,500 – \$20,000	Higher for themes/title sequences
Cable TV	\$500 – \$5,000	Reality TV can be very active
Major film (studio)	\$10,000 – \$500,000+	Dependent on scene prominence
Independent film	\$500 – \$5,000	Often back-end heavy
National TV commercial	\$25,000 – \$500,000	Most lucrative single placement
Regional/local ad	\$1,000 – \$10,000	
Video game (per title)	\$2,500 – \$50,000	Ongoing royalties possible
YouTube (brand channel)	\$200 – \$2,500	Growing market
Trailer / promo	\$5,000 – \$75,000	Highly competitive, high reward

// MAKING YOUR MUSIC SYNC-READY

Music supervisors receive thousands of submissions. These are the technical and creative requirements to be taken seriously:

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

- Deliver stems with every submission

At minimum: instrumental, a cappella, TV mix (no lead vocal). Full stems preferred: drums, bass, guitars, keys, vocals separate.

- WAV files at 24-bit / 48kHz

Some supervisors require 96kHz. Always ask before delivery.

- Clean metadata on every file

File name, song title, composer, publisher, ISRC, BPM, key, mood, genre — all fields filled

- Clear all samples BEFORE pitching

An uncleared sample makes your track unlicensable. Supervisors will not touch it.

- Register with PRO and MLC before pitching

Supervisors need to verify clean chain of title before any deal

CREATIVE CONSIDERATIONS

- Instrumentals and underscores are highly sought after

Many scenes need music without lyrics — having instrumentals ready dramatically expands your placement potential

- Avoid dated production sounds

Trendy production dates quickly. Timeless arrangements have longer shelf lives in sync catalogs.

- Think in scenes when writing

Ask: what scene would this soundtrack? Build a catalog that covers a range of moods.

- Tempo and energy variety in your catalog

Supervisors search by mood and tempo — a varied catalog means more search results

// HOW TO GET YOUR MUSIC IN FRONT OF SUPERVISORS

1

Music Libraries

Non-exclusive libraries (Musicbed, Artlist, Epidemic Sound, Pond5) accept submissions and actively pitch to supervisors. Non-exclusive means you retain the right to pitch elsewhere. Start [here](#).

2

Sync Agents

A sync agent pitches your catalog directly to supervisors in exchange for a commission (typically 25-50% of the fee). A good sync agent with existing relationships is worth their cut.

3

Direct Supervisor Relationships

Music supervisors attend SXSW, Sundance, and music industry conferences. Building direct relationships takes time but results in the most consistent and lucrative placements.

4

Unsolicited Submissions

Most major studios and networks do not accept unsolicited music. Focus on libraries and agents first, then build relationships that open direct doors.

"Sync is not passive income — it is active catalog management. The artists who win in sync are the ones who treat it like a business."